

COLUMBUS, CHRISTOPHER



CHRISTOPHER COLUMBUS was the first European since the Vikings to visit America. In the 1400s, Europeans did not know that America existed – they thought that Asia faced Europe across the Atlantic Ocean. In 1492, Columbus set sail from Spain across the

Atlantic. He hoped to open up a trade route to Asia that would be quicker than the old land journey. He found some islands he believed were the East Indies, off what was presumed to be the Asian mainland. What he had really discovered was a continent soon to be known as America by the Europeans.



Early life

Columbus was born in the port of Genoa, Italy in 1451 and was named after St Christopher, the patron saint of travellers. His father was a weaver, and Christopher had little formal education. As a boy, he went to sea, and later worked in Lisbon, Portugal, where he drew sea charts for Portuguese sailors.



The port of Genoa in the 16th century

Crossing the Atlantic

While the Portuguese and other sailors were trying to find a sea route to Asia by sailing south and east round Africa, Columbus believed that, since the world was round, he could reach Asia from the opposite direction by sailing west across the Atlantic. In 1492, he persuaded the king and queen of Spain to finance his voyage, and set sail with three ships, the largest of which was the three-masted *Santa Maria*. At his first attempt, he landed in the Bahamas. Columbus, however, thought these islands were off the coast of Asia.

Navigation

Columbus had few instruments to help him navigate across the ocean. He used a crosstaff and astrolabe to calculate the ship's latitude, but had no way of knowing its longitude. Despite this lack of information, he managed to navigate successfully back home to Europe.



Astrolabe



Using the crosstaff



Crosstaff

The *Santa Maria*

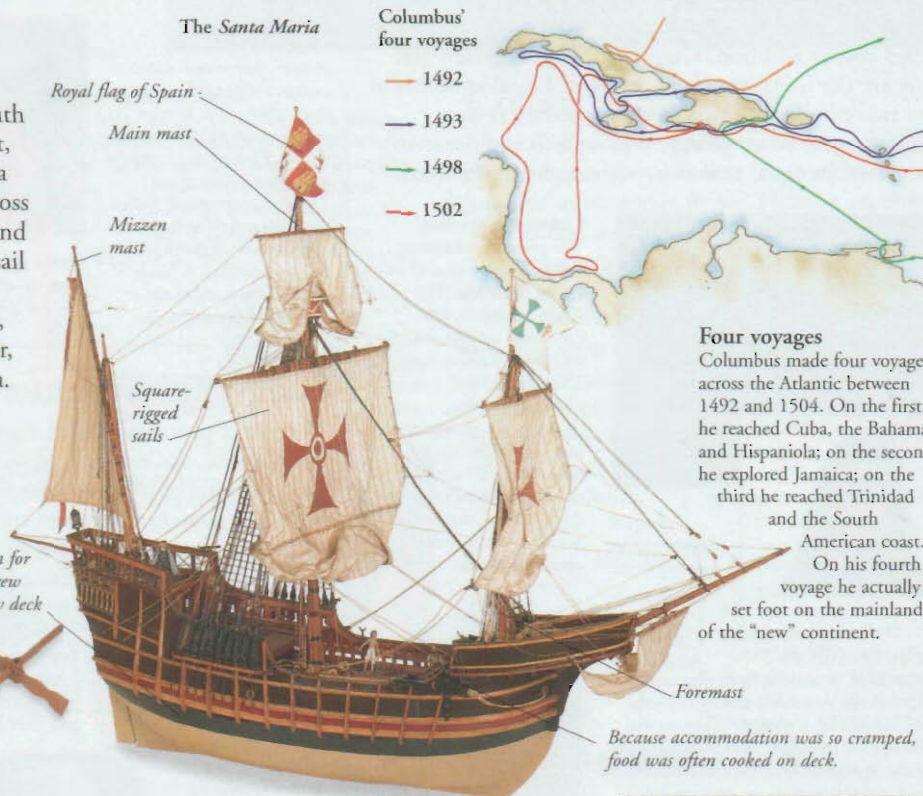
Royal flag of Spain

Main mast

Mizzen mast

Square-rigged sails

Room for 40 crew below deck



Columbus' four voyages

- 1492
- 1493
- 1498
- 1502

Four voyages

Columbus made four voyages across the Atlantic between 1492 and 1504. On the first, he reached Cuba, the Bahamas, and Hispaniola; on the second, he explored Jamaica; on the third he reached Trinidad and the South American coast. On his fourth voyage he actually set foot on the mainland of the "new" continent.

Because accommodation was so cramped, food was often cooked on deck.

West Indies

Columbus was amazed by the beauty and lush vegetation of the Caribbean islands, but he was disappointed that he had not found the rich trading cities of Asia. However, his discoveries encouraged other Europeans to visit the area in the coming centuries, founding colonies

and opening up new trade links between Europe and the Caribbean.



Columbus arriving at the island of Hispaniola

New discoveries

While in the West Indies, Columbus and his crew tasted new foods, such as pineapple, potatoes, and sweetcorn. They saw people sleeping in hammocks, and observed the Arawak peoples of Cuba rolling up dried tobacco leaves and smoking them.



Later life

In 1493, Columbus was made governor-general of all the lands he discovered, but he was a poor administrator. In 1500, there were complaints about his rule of Hispaniola. As a result, Columbus was arrested and sent back to Spain in chains. He retired to Seville, where he died in 1506.



CHRISTOPHER COLUMBUS

- 1451 Born in Genoa, Italy
- 1476 Becomes a chartmaker in Lisbon, Portugal
- 1479 Marries Filipa de Perestrelo e Moniz
- 1484 Becomes master mariner in Portuguese merchant service
- 1492 First voyage: sails across Atlantic Ocean in search of new route to Asia
- 1493–96 Second voyage
- 1493 Establishes European colony on Hispaniola
- 1498–1500 Third voyage
- 1502–04 Fourth and final voyage
- 1506 Dies in Seville, Spain

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